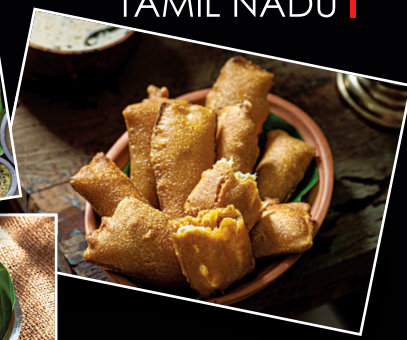
The Delicious Flavours of TAMIL NADU







The cuisine of Tamil Nadu displays a fascinating repertoire which makes the best use of the available produce



The influence that Tamil food has over the culinary world is easily established by the fact that the word 'curry' comes from the Tamil word 'kari'. The hallmark of Tamil food are fresh flavours, the nuanced use of spices, and techniques like grinding and fermentation. Each dish reflects the state's distinct history, culture, and geography. Although the ubiquitous idli-dosa-vada-sambar are justly famous, they are merely the tip of the iceberg. There is much more to Tamil cuisine, including a variety of regional variations and heirloom recipes which are passionately being revived.

Rice is a staple food in Tamil Nadu, and the state boasts a wide variety of rice dishes. These include variations like lemon rice, tomato rice, tamarind rice, coconut rice and curd rice. Of course, there is Pongal, the porridge-like dish made with new rice to celebrate the harvest. No meal in Tamil Nadu is perhaps complete without generous servings of sambar. Dosas and idlis too are always served with sambar and a coconut chutney. Apart from sambar and rice, a basic meal would require vegetable dishes like the tamarind-based kuzhambu and a delicate poriyal to complete it. Slightly more elaborate meals would include paruppu, pachadi and buttermilk. Rasam is often served as a starter or as an accompaniment to meals. While sambar is a watery and tangy preparation of lentils which also uses vegetables like drumsticks, carrots, and onions, rasam is thinner still, akin to a spicy and sour soup made from tamarind, tomatoes, and spices. Paruppu is a dal-like preparation which is thicker than sambar.

The regional cuisine of Tamil Nadu can be divided into five broad categories: Thanjavur cuisine, Mudaliar cuisine, Chettinad cuisine, Kongu Nadu cuisine and Tamil Sahibu or Tamil Muslim cuisine.

The Chettiars of Chettinad were wealthy traders with business relations with Southeast Asia and their food reflects this influence. They were involved in the spice trade, and have introduced pepper, cloves and cardamom to the repertoire of Tamil food. Although they are known for their spicy non-vegetarian dishes, they have a large number of vegetarian dishes as well.

The cuisine of Thanjavur is a mix of traditional Brahmin, Mukkulathor and Maratha cuisines, drawing from the communities that have lived in and around the area. The Thavala Adai pancakes made of lentils and rice batter from Thanjavur are famous. The Mudaliars who were historically wealthy farmers have dishes displaying a predominance of vegetables. An iconic dish is the Vazhaipoo Thattai, a vada made of banana flower and Bengal gram. Then there is the brinjal dish, Kathirikai Chops, generally accompanied with appams. The traditional Kongu people were mostly vegetarians. Their Opputtu is a dish made with rice, chickpea, palm or cane jaggery, cardamom and ghee. One of the popular non-vegetarian dishes from this region is the Dindigul Biryani.

In the coastal areas, seafood is a significant part of the state's cuisine. Dishes like Fish fry, prawn fry, and crab fry are popular here as is fish curry, which is made with tamarind, coconut milk, and a blend of spices.

Tamil Nadu is also famous for its sweet dishes, which are often made with jaggery. Payasam, a sweet milk-based dessert, is a staple at festivals and special occasions. Another popular sweet dish is the adhirasam, a deep-fried pastry made from rice flour, jaggery, and cardamom powder. Of course, Tamils can't live without their beloved filter coffee, which is frothed up and coled down at the same time by pouring it from the glass to the dabarah (small bowl) swiftly back and forth.

The cuisine of Tamil Nadu is truly a treasure trove for the passionate foodie.